

7 Costly and Potentially Disastrous Mistakes People Make When Deciding Where To Get Dental Implants

By Dr Ferhan Ahmed – Implant Specialist & Founder, FAME Dentistry, Glasgow

I'm Dr Ferhan Ahmed. Thank you for taking the time to read this guide.

I want to start with something you may not expect a dentist to say: the most important decision you will make in this entire process has nothing to do with the procedure itself. It's the decision about who you trust to carry it out.

Get that right, and almost everything else follows. Get it wrong, and the consequences – financial, physical, and emotional – can be significant and long-lasting.

In my years as an implant specialist, I've been privileged to help hundreds of patients transform their confidence, their comfort, and their quality of life through implant dentistry. Many of them came to me after a difficult experience elsewhere. Some had lost money. Some had lost time. A few had lost both and were starting the process over again.

What I noticed, without exception, was that the mistakes they made weren't about dentistry. They were about due diligence. About the signals they missed, the questions they didn't think to ask, and the assumptions that seemed reasonable until with hindsight, they weren't.

This guide is my attempt to share what I've learned – plainly, honestly and with your best interests as the only agenda.

I hope it gives you the clarity and the confidence to make a decision that's exactly right for you.

MISTAKE #1

Judging a practice by its own marketing.

A beautiful website. Impressive before-and-after photographs. A string of glowing five-star reviews. These are now the baseline in private dentistry but they sometimes tell you far less than you might imagine.

Anyone can commission a professional photoshoot. Reviews can be encouraged, curated, and in some cases entirely manufactured. Marketing is, by definition, a practice telling its own story and then telling that story in its most favourable light.

There is a far more reliable signal that can be gained by asking this question: 'What percentage of a dental practice's new patients arrive through referrals from other dentists?'

[CALL OUT] *When a general dentist refers a patient to a specialist, their own professional reputation is on the line. They don't refer lightly and they certainly don't refer repeatedly to anyone who doesn't consistently deliver.*

A high referral rate from other dental professionals is the closest thing to an independent endorsement that dentistry has to offer. It's peer review, not self-promotion.

So alongside anything you read on a practice's website, ask directly: 'What percentage of your implant patients are referred to you by other dentists?' Listen carefully and the answer to that question and the confidence with which it's answered, will tell you a great deal.

MISTAKE #2

Being Seduced By Offers That Seem Too Good To Be True.

In recent years, the competition for patients in private dentistry has led to increasingly aggressive advertising. Headline prices designed to catch attention. Time-limited offers conceived to trigger a fear of missing out. And those promises of 'same day teeth' and transformations delivered in a single appointment.

Let me be direct about one of these marketing practices, namely 'same day teeth'. This is a phrase that taps into the universal human need for instant gratification and a modern day craving for convenience. In reality though, 'same day teeth' is a smoke and mirrors promise. Yes, temporary, serviceable teeth in a day is achievable. But the final, permanent restoration – done properly – will take several months. There are no shortcuts worth taking in implant surgery and any claims otherwise should be taken as warning signals about the integrity of the dentist you are dealing with.

On pricing specifically: if the number you're being quoted seems remarkably low, there are almost certainly non-optional extras that won't appear until you're committed to treatment. The discovery of those extras tends to happen at a point in the process when it's difficult to walk away.

[CALL OUT] The very best implant dentists don't need to compete on price or urgency. They are busy because their patients recommend them – and that constant flow of word-of-mouth introductions means they can focus entirely on the quality of their work, rather than patient acquisition.

A useful question to ask any practice you're considering: 'What percentage of your new patients come to you through word-of-mouth recommendations?' A good dentist will proudly be able to answer that question very specifically. So if the answer is low or vague, ask yourself why.

MISTAKE #3

Dismissing the small things during your first visit.

There's a principle I've come to believe deeply: the same mindset that forgets your name at reception is the mindset that will be in the room when your surgery takes place.

Attention to detail is not something a team switches on for clinical procedures and switches off for everything else. It is either a culture – embedded in every interaction, every day – or it isn't.

So pay close attention to what happens before you even sit in the chair.

When you call to make an enquiry, are you spoken to as if you matter? When you arrive, does the team seem genuinely pleased to see you? If you're offered a drink and you ask for tea, do you get tea? If you were promised a written treatment plan, does it arrive without you having to chase it?

[CALL OUT] None of these things are minor. They are evidence. They tell you whether this practice considers the patient experience to be as important as the clinical outcome. Important to you, because in the very best practices, those two things are inseparable.

You are about to invest significant time, money, and trust in a team of people. Observing how that team behaves when they think it doesn't count, will be a great indicator of exactly how they'll behave when it does.

So, I would advise you not to dismiss small oversights. The team that genuinely cares about your experience on the way to achieving the perfect outcome will get the small things right. If they don't, you have information that should be strongly considered before you commit.

MISTAKE #4

Trying to combine your implants with a holiday abroad.

The headline prices for dental treatment overseas are genuinely attention-grabbing. For some types of dentistry, this option may well make sense. For implant surgery specifically, however, I'd encourage you to look very carefully before going down this route.

The first issue is like-for-like comparison. Worldwide, there are over 300 different implant systems in use. The price difference between them – and the difference in long-term outcomes – can be significant. When an overseas price seems dramatically lower, it's worth asking what system is being used and whether your records and X-rays will be compatible with a UK practice if you ever need follow-up treatment.

The second issue is diagnostic rigour. Because a face-to-face consultation isn't always practical before you travel, many overseas providers work from older 2D X-ray imaging. A thorough UK specialist will insist on a full examination and use the most current diagnostic tools including 3D CBCT scanning. This enables them to deliver better custom work and identify any potential complications before treatment begins, not after work has begun.

The third issue is what happens next. As we are about to discuss in mistake #6, implant surgery is not a one-visit procedure. There are follow-ups, adjustments and in some cases, complications that require prompt attention. If your dentist is in another country, that follow-up care becomes an issue you have to deal with, along with the additional cost involved and substantial inconvenience.

What appears to be a saving on day one can look very different eighteen months later.

MISTAKE #5

Assuming that one implant dentist is much like another.

As with every skilled profession, the range of ability in implant dentistry is wider than most people realise. Two dentists with the same qualifications, treating the same patient with the same clinical needs, may approach the case differently and subsequently produce meaningfully different outcomes.

Experience is the key variable. But experience in implant dentistry can't just be measured by years in practice. It means years of doing implants. It means doing implants on a weekly basis. This consistency and volume of reps is the only way advanced technical ability and skill can be gained. A dentist with thirty years in general practice may place fewer implants in a career than a specialist places in a single month.

The questions that actually matter are these: 'How many implants have you placed?' 'How frequently do you perform this procedure?' 'What is your complication rate, and how do you manage complications when they arise?'

[CALL OUT] *The answers you're looking for: hundreds of cases, every week, and a transparent and confident response to the complication question. Evasion or vagueness on any of those three points is a warning signal you should pay attention to.*

It's also worth knowing that many of the most experienced implant specialists receive a significant proportion of their patients through referrals from general dentists who recognise the limits of their own expertise. If the practice you're considering is primarily a referral destination for other dental professionals, that is one of the strongest indicators of genuine specialisation available to you.

MISTAKE #6

Not asking what the practice's commitment to you looks like after your procedure.

Most of the questions patients think to ask are about what happens before and during treatment. Very few think to ask about what happens after and yet that is precisely where the character of a practice is most clearly revealed.

Once the procedure is complete and the invoice is paid, some practices consider their job done. The relationship, such as it was, quiet suddenly ends. The service provided is transactional in nature. If you have questions, you might get beyond a generic response. If you have concerns, you'll navigate a generic process. If you have complications, you'll discover how well the practice actually values your long-term wellbeing.

The best practices operate on an entirely different philosophy: that the relationship with a patient is just beginning when the procedure ends. They have structured aftercare protocols. A named patient coordinator who remains your point of contact throughout your recovery. Clear communication about what to expect, when to call, and what they will do if anything doesn't go to plan. The service provided is relational in nature.

[CALL OUT] *Ask specifically: 'What does your aftercare process look like? Who is my point of contact during recovery? What is your protocol if I have concerns or complications?' A great practice will answer these questions in detail even before you ask.*

This matters more than most patients realise. Implant outcomes are influenced not just by the surgery itself, but by the quality of post-operative care and the responsiveness of the team during the healing process. You are not buying a procedure. You are entering a relationship and as such, you should put in the appropriate effort to choosing who you will have that relationship with.

MISTAKE #7

Making a decision before you're ready – or feeling pressured to do so.

Dental implant surgery is a significant commitment – financially, medically, and personally. The decision about which practice to trust with that commitment deserves proper consideration and any practice worth choosing will tell you exactly that.

If you ever sense that someone is hovering with a card machine, if you're presented with a 'limited time' price, or any kind of urgency to 'commit today', it's advisable to take a step back. A good medical specialist wants you to take the time to be certain, because uncertain patients often make difficult recoveries and that can result in unhappy outcomes for everyone.

A written treatment plan, the time to read it carefully and raise questions, and the space to sleep on your decision are not concessions. They are the standard you should expect, without having to ask for them.

Take the time you need. Ask every question you have. And if a practice ever makes you feel that asking questions is an inconvenience, then walk away.

[CALL OUT] *You are about to make a decision that will affect your confidence, your health, and your daily quality of life, for the rest of your life. So this particular decision deserves your full attention and full consideration. The right practice will not only accommodate that but they will respect you for it.*

A final word – and an invitation.

If you've read this far, it's clear that you already approach important decisions differently from most people. You want to understand every aspect of the decision you are making and you take due diligence seriously. That's a quality I admire and I hope you find this guide useful in your process.

Now, I'd like to take just a moment to tell you a little about our approach at FAME Dentistry, because it's directly relevant to everything in this guide.

We measure the quality of our patient experience using something called the Net Promoter Score. This is the same evaluation method used by some of the world's most admiredV businesses. These businesses include Apple, Tesla and Amazon, who use NPS to quantify how they are valued by the customers they serve. Our ambition is to achieve the highest Net Promoter Score of any dental practice in the world.

This publicly stated intention shapes everything we do at FAME Dentistry – including how we hire and train our team. This is what ensures we have the capability to deliver an excellent experience and clinical outcomes through your entire relationship with us – from your very first phone call to your final follow-up. It means that the principles in this guide aren't just advice we offer to patients looking for the best implant choice for them. They are the standard we hold ourselves to every single day.

If you'd like to have a conversation about whether implants are right for you, and whether FAME Dentistry is the right place for you to have them, I'd like that very much.

To arrange a consultation, contact us directly:

[QR code]

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